[Karzai's] feet'.[120] Worried that Karzai may cut rash political deals with the Taliban or Pakistan to ensure his survival, Narayanan repeatedly assured him that India was with him and 'if he [Karzai] needs anything he should come to us [India]'.[121] As Bhadrakumar, a retired conciliator active in New Delhi's policy commentariat, noted, at a time when Karzai was being 'vilified and demonised, ridiculed and snubbed alternatively by Washington', New Delhi demonstratively held his hand in solidarity.[122] The strength of India's support to Afghanistan in light of such political balancing within Kabul was tested when Karzai demanded from New Delhi a wish list of military hardware.

Military wish list

In May 2013, with the spectre of NATO withdrawal looming large and skirmishes between the Afghan and Pakistani forces along the Durand Line at an all-time high, Karzai visited India and handed New Delhi a 'wish list' of military hardware. Not the first of its kind, the list included combat helicopters, 105-mm artillery, An.32 medium-lift aircraft, bridge-laying equipment, and trucks.[123] This hardware would not have propelled a qualitative shift in Afghanistan's military disparity vis-à-vis Pakistan, but it was a powerful signal to Islamabad as to where Karzai stood. India, however, remained hesitant, buttressing the perception of its half-hearted support for Afghanistan.[124] In fact, in 2003, Afghanistan had an open offer from New Delhi to seek lethal light weaponry for the ANSF. Kabul, however, was not keen to seek military assistance from India at that point in time and wanted to coordinate 'anything' in that sector with the US. That India was vacillating on its offer a decade later fed into Kabul's doubts about New Delhi's reliability as a regional security provider.[125] Afghan foreign minister Zalmai Rassoul stated in 2013 that 'a decade ago the BJP government wanted to help us [Afghanistan] militarily but we refused, due to Pakistani sensitivities. This time, we are keen, but India is hesitant.' Responding to Rassoul's statement the MEA gave an elusive response that, 'there was a discussion on political and security issues [with Rassoul], without going into specifics. But India is ready to stand by Afghanistan as a close, friendly and historic neighbour through these transitions